TRANSPORTATION SECURITY ADMINISTRATION

Security in TSA





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OVERVIEW

Agenda

01 Problem Statement

02 Potential Solutions

03 Solution for Implementation

04 Steps for Implementation and Related Financials

05 Proof of Concept

06 Vision for the Future

> *"$7.4B spent by airlines on aviation security every year ... but our passengers only see hassle."*
>
> — BISIGNANI

The problem isn't how much is spent, it's where it's spent.

Problem Statement

How can TSA prevent dangerous objects and credible threats from entering aircraft, rather than trying to predict which passengers might be dangerous?

TSA must have an airport-screening system that accurately identifies passengers with dangerous objects.

MINIMIZE

- False positives
- Discrimination
- Unnecessary delays
- Costs

Potential Solutions

OPTION 1 — Removes SPOT

Evidence-Based Screening

- Intelligence-driven detection
- Directs intensity checks using verified security threat intelligence
- All passengers required to undergo the same process despite pre-clear status

MAIN CONS

Time to program the technology systems, risk of glitches

OPTION 2 — Improves SPOT

Reform & Standardize SPOT for All

- Standardized "threat indicators", removing speculation
- Eliminates security gaps by applying multiple physical checks across all access points

MAIN CONS

Extensive officer training, difficulty removing existing bias, expensive

OPTION 3 — Improves SPOT

Focus SPOT Investment for Regular Entry & Intense Pre-Screening

- Scales background vetting to pre-classify travelers and accelerate checkpoints
- Reduced SPOT officers as they are now reserved for regular-entry travelers

MAIN CONS

Requires public acceptance, high costs for additional background-vetting platforms

Decision Matrix

Highest score: Evidence-Based Targeted Screening · 4.45 / 5

Decision Criterion	Weight	1. Evidence-Based Targeted Screening	2. Reform & Standardize SPOT	3. Expanded Pre-Screening & Risk Classification
Threat Detection / Safety	30%	5	3	3
Screening Accuracy	25%	5	2	3
Fairness / Objectivity	20%	4	2	4
Passenger Throughput / Experience	15%	4	3	5
Cost / Ease of Implementation	10%	3	4	4
Weighted Score / 5	100%	4.45	2.65	3.60

Screen for Objects, Not Behavior by Redirecting SPOT Spending

Replace SPOT with an upgrades higher-tech Direct Threat Detection System focused on spotting dangerous objects in security.

1. Redirect SPOT officers and budget toward the highest quality programmed X-ray screeners.

2. Standardize objective, documented triggers for secondary screening in place of SPOT officer judgment calls.

TSA should continuously measure where threats and screening failures occur (carry-on baggage versus passengers) to guide where funding is redirected.

WHY ARE WE GETTING RID OF SPOT?

0.52%

"Only 0.52% of passengers referred through SPOT were ultimately arrested, and none of those arrests involved an obvious threat to air-travel safety."

A Four-Part Strategy

01 Phase out SPOT as a primary screening method

02 Strengthen carry-on baggage threat detection

- Implement technology programmed to identify key hazards (e.g., guns, knives, explosives)

03 Strengthen detection of threats carried on the passenger

- Invest in advanced technology trained to better detect threats contained on a person and pay attention to areas commonly used to conceal weapons
- All passengers required to walk through two detectors

04 Create clear triggers for secondary screening

- Establish criteria that trigger officer secondary screening (e.g., a sensor detects 3+ potential hazard spots)
- Secondary screening may include walking through an additional detector

Why This Works

It fixes the root problem, not the symptom

What TSA needs	SPOT today	Our solution
Catch threats	0.52% of referrals arrested, none for an air-travel threat	Analogic ConneCT CT + R&S QPS201 scanners find the object itself
No profiling	Officer judgment calls, flagged by the Government Accountability Office (GAO) and American Civil Liberties Union (ACLU)	A scanner alarm is the only trigger, same for everyone
Less hassle	13-minute full search per SPOT referral	Check only flagged concerns with an IONSCAN 600 trace test
Smart spending	$200M a year on SPOT	Same $200M buys 140–200 upgraded lanes a year

Source: Ivey case W39843; GAO-14-159 (2013).

Implementation Specifics

Funded by redirecting SPOT spending

1	**Carry-on CT scanner** Analogic ConneCT · 3-D imaging, auto threat detection	**$650–800K**
2	**On-person body scanner** Rohde & Schwarz QPS201 · millimeter-wave imaging	**$250–350K**
3	**Secondary-screening triggers**	**Minimal**
4	**Installation & training** Checkpoint and floor work, screener image drills	**$125–250K**
	TOTAL PER LANE	**$1.0–1.4M**

PHASE OUT SPOT

$200M

SPOT budget each year

÷ $1.0–1.4M per lane

140–200

Upgraded lanes per year

YEAR 1 · PILOT

$100M → 70–100 lanes at busiest airports; SPOT officers retrained

YEAR 2 · SCALE

$200M → 140–200 more lanes

05 · PROOF OF CONCEPT

Heathrow Airport

Independent testing backs the exact detection this proposal relies on

1 Chosen after head-to-head testing

Heathrow selected QPS201 after performance tests showed very high detection capability and low false-alarm rates.

2 Finds what actually matters

Testing confirmed QPS201 can recognize small objects concealed on a person with very high detection probability.

3 Live at full scale

QPS201 now screens every passenger, staff member, and contractor entering airside areas at Heathrow.

4 Faster, not just safer

The rollout doubled screening throughput compared with the scanners it replaced.

PROVEN PERFORMANCE

2×

Faster screening throughput vs. prior scanners

TSA + ECAC

Certified & approved

QPS201 scanner passed ECAC's aviation security testing & detection criteria

The UK tried a SPOT-style program too – and still chose to detect the object, not the person.

Source: Rohde & Schwarz, "QPS201 makes air travel safer at Heathrow Airport" case study.

Start with 8–10 Pilot Airports (2025–2026)

Diverse, high-priority airports to test and refine the new approach



Denver isn't a pilot: it's a proof point. Its checkpoints are already running the exact technology this plan scales nationwide.

Vision for the Future

By 2035, TSA will have phased out SPOT and deployed best-in-class detection technology across U.S. airports, directly identifying threats and creating a safer, faster, and more seamless travel experience.

1

2025–2026

Design & Pilot

- Install advanced screening technology at 8–10 pilot airports
- Begin phasing down SPOT

2

2027–2028

Initial Rollout

- Expand to ~50 high-volume, high-risk airports
- Reallocate SPOT personnel for secondary screening purposes

3

2029–2031

National Expansion

- Scale to the majority of U.S. airports (~250+)
- Standardize training and performance metrics

4

2032–2034

Full Implementation

- Complete nationwide deployment (~450 airports)
- SPOT fully phased out

5

2035

Future State

- Best-in-class detection technology at all U.S. airports
- Data-driven, adaptive operations